Police gun-snatching claims in West Bengal

Historical headline audit, recent reported encounters, and the probability of temporal clustering. Prepared 27 October 2026.

What the evidence supports

Three distinct fatal encounters in 2026 are documented in news reports that attribute an immediate police-gun-snatching claim to officers. These are reported claims. The evidence reviewed here does not establish whether the guns were seized as described or adjudicate whether the killings were unlawful. [1-5]

Reported incident	Provisional event date, IST	Reported mechanism
Baruipur, South 24 Parganas; Prabash Mondal	8 July 2026, about 00:45	Crime reconstruction; alleged seizure of officer firearm, firing and fatal police response
Gaighata/Bongaon; Prahlad Das	27 October, about 02:30-03:30; some reports say late 26 October	Crime reconstruction; alleged officer firearm seizure and fatal police response
Samserganj/Dhuliyan, Murshidabad; Samayun Sheikh	27 October, about 14:30 in later TOI report	Crime reconstruction; CID alleges weapon seizure and firing before fatal response

Name spellings vary across reports. Location, original criminal case and timing identify each incident. Multiple articles about one incident are not additional events. The October pair is reported approximately 12 hours apart; rolling-24-hour analysis is more robust than a calendar-date claim to the midnight discrepancy. A later TOI account supplies 02:30 and 14:30 timings. [3-5,17]

Rarity: the qualified answer

West Bengal had few officially registered encounter-death cases in FY2019-20 through FY2021-22, and the specific full sequence is not explicit in the historical headline candidates reviewed. TOI describes the same-day pair as possibly unprecedented since the Naxalite period; that is a journalistic assessment, not a validated historical census. [17] **The evidence cannot yet quantify an increase in this mechanism or attribute it to a party.** Missing bodies and unequal ascertainment prevent a clean comparison.

A conditional independent-timing illustration gives a 2.66% chance that any pair among three events shares a date in 112 days, or 5.26% that any pair is within 24 hours. These are selected-window benchmarks, not calibrated p-values or probabilities that the accounts are false.

Earlier case under a broader definition: a March 2025 TOI report from Jalpaiguri describes a fatal BSF shooting after a group allegedly attempted weapon seizure. It does not expressly attribute the attempt to the man killed. This is a border-force/group-attempt sensitivity case, separate from police-custody reconstructions. [18]

1. Corpus coverage and deduplication

The original dated files contain 3,930,496 distinct normalized date-headline records, spanning 2 January 2001 to 31 December 2023. Geography screening identifies 136,404 WB-related records; 120,995 have a regional desk/URL proxy. These are news records, not incidents or a census of West Bengal news.

Source	Raw rows	Observed date range	Unique within source
Main headline file	3,876,557	2001-01-02 to 2023-06-30	3,704,138
Export named 2002_2003	52,324	2004-01-01 to 2004-12-31	51,624
2005-2014 link export	1,118,803	2005-01-01 to 2014-12-31	1,098,919
2015-2023 link export	1,614,529	2015-01-01 to 2023-12-31	1,548,026

Two large derivative exports are byte-identical aliases (SHA-256), excluded as duplicate sources. The folder copy was not pooled. Other tiny files are empty, undated, or overlap the dated sample. Excluded: 1,670 missing-date rows and 4,330 empty-headline rows across distinct files. Raw counts above include excluded rows. Full file hashes and line-level candidate provenance are retained.

Year	All unique records	WB proxy	Year	All unique records	WB proxy
2001	55,461	2,909	2013	263,956	7,211
2002	111,521	6,706	2014	246,752	6,296
2003	96,297	5,961	2015	250,550	5,877
2004	64,417	3,577	2016	250,221	5,666
2005	46,387	1,619	2017	263,501	6,742
2006	56,246	1,522	2018	244,071	7,049
2007	83,536	2,954	2019	177,150	6,125
2008	125,440	3,672	2020	181,082	6,657
2009	202,573	6,739	2021	181,121	7,610
2010	166,036	4,898	2022	178,050	10,131
2011	246,735	6,975	2023	174,628	11,697
2012	264,765	7,811			

There are 8,353 observed dates out of 8,399 dates in the inclusive range. Having some rows on a date does not establish a complete archive. The scraper assigns archive-list dates to links; these are not independently verified article publication dates or encounter dates. Original files were left unchanged.

2. Text-as-data method and validation

The estimand is the presence of a **reported claim**: a suspect or accused person attempted or completed seizure of an officer firearm, immediately followed by police shooting that person in West Bengal. Fatal and nonfatal outcomes must be coded separately. Earlier weapon theft, weapons supplied by an accomplice, police victims and confiscated illegal arms are distinct categories.

Retrieval route	Definition	Unique records
A: broad geography and violence	WB desk/URL or place-name proxy, plus shooting/encounter words or police-and-death words	3,271
B: weapon taking, all locations	Gun/weapon terms plus snatch/grab/wrest/seize/disarm/overpower stems	977
C: encounters, all locations	Encounter/gunfight/shootout/crossfire plus police, suspect or death terms	3,154
Union of A, B, C	Overlapping routes deduplicated by archive/publication-date field plus normalized headline	7,356

Normalization uses Unicode NFKC, lowercasing, punctuation-to-space and whitespace collapse. Full regular expressions, original text and candidate source-line references are saved. Broad words deliberately overretrieve: for example, police seizure of illegal arms is not suspect seizure of a police gun. Date-headline deduplication can merge distinct same-title items or retain one article listed on different dates; only case review can create an event roster.

Independent subagent review	Result	Interpretation
All 52 WB-proxy route-B records	49 other; 3 unresolved; 0 explicit full target sequence	Only four literally use snatch; no historical zero-event inference
206 broader primary focus headlines	16 flagged for body review	Screening of relevant wording, not a completed body census
Simple random sample of 100 WB-proxy negatives	0 visible missed shooting/encounter headlines; 1 ambiguous violence headline	Seed 20261027; frame 125,579 unique primary records outside route A

The negative audit checks headline-visible retrieval misses only. It cannot estimate how often article bodies contain an omitted mechanism. No precision/recall estimate for the full target event is claimed. Separate model passes are useful checks, but do not substitute for independent human coding, adjudication or measured intercoder agreement. This follows the problem-specific validation emphasis of Grimmer and Stewart. [6]

Historical body checks

Reviewed reports include Kulti (2002), Howrah (2015), Titagarh follow-up (2015), Kankinara (2019) and New Town (2021). None of those reviewed bodies supplies the immediate police-gun-taking mechanism. A 2005 Kolkata-category encounter actually occurred in Lucknow. The 2014 Haridevpur report has the reverse outcome: the accused reportedly killed a homeguard and survived. Behala (2012), three snatch-only headlines and some initial reports remain unresolved. These are bounded checks, not proof of absence. [7-12,12a]

3. Calculating the 5.26% benchmark

Assume exactly three event times independently drawn uniformly over a fixed interval of T days. Order them t1 < t2 < t3. There is no pair within 24 hours precisely when t2 - t1 > 1 and t3 - t2 > 1. Subtract the required gaps, producing t1, t2 - 1 and t3 - 2. The ordered configurations now occupy a simplex with side T - 2, rather than T. Three-dimensional volume scales with the cube of that side.

$P(\text{any pair within 24 hours} \mid N=3, T) = 1 - ((T - 2)/T)^3$

At T=112: $1 - (110/112)^3 = 0.05262049$ = **5.262%**. This includes any of the three possible pairs, not just the named October pair. For calendar dates, all three dates differ with probability $(T-1)(T-2)/T^2$. Its complement is the shared-date probability.

Illustrative window ending 27 October	Days	Any shared date	Any pair within 24h
2026-01-01	300	0.998%	1.987%
2026-05-09	172	1.737%	3.448%
2026-07-08	112	2.663%	5.262%

Window selection matters. July 8 was chosen because an event occurred then; October 27 was noticed because of the cluster. These are not independently chosen testing boundaries. Exactly three must also be the complete event count. The table does not correct every search across dates, states, narratives or window lengths. The continuous 112-day calculation treats the selected calendar window as a 112-day interval; actual timestamps are uncertain.

An alternative: assume a baseline rate

Under an independent constant-rate Poisson process, let m = r/365, where r is the assumed annual number of reported events of this exact type. P(two or more on a specified day) = 1 - exp(-m)(1+m). This is a different question from noticing a close pair afterward. [13]

Assumed events/year	2+ on specified day	Any 2+ date in a year	Next event within 24h
1	0.00037%	0.14%	0.27%
3	0.00336%	1.22%	0.82%
5	0.00930%	3.34%	1.36%
10	0.03685%	12.59%	2.70%
20	0.14475%	41.06%	5.33%

These rates are assumptions, not fitted estimates from the headline corpus. Do not infer that a low probability of clustering under this model implies an equally high probability of fabricated accounts.

4. Historical West Bengal and party comparisons

Official parliamentary replies give a useful broader benchmark. The table below reports **NHRC cases registered concerning encounter deaths**, rather than gun-snatching claims, deduplicated incidents or adjudicated unlawful killings. Selected states illustrate both high and low counts. They are not a representative party comparison. [14-15]

State	Government grouping in these years	FY2019-20	FY2020-21	FY2021-22
West Bengal	Non-BJP	1	0	2
Uttar Pradesh	BJP-led	26	16	11
Assam	BJP-led	4	4	18
Gujarat	BJP-led	0	0	0
Andhra Pradesh	Non-BJP	1	1	3
Telangana	Non-BJP	4	5	2
Chhattisgarh	Non-BJP	39	24	30

The historical WB entries are low. However, high counts also appear in non-BJP Chhattisgarh, while BJP-governed Gujarat reports zero in these years. These examples do not support a simple claim that party identity alone determines encounter-death counts. Variation in conflict, population, police operations and registration may matter. The table does not identify which encounters involved gun-snatching claims.

All three identified 2026 WB incidents fall after the May 9 government transition, verified by a Prime Minister's Office release. Their occurrence after the transition is descriptive; temporal sequence alone cannot identify the effect of the new government. [16]

The March 2025 Jalpaiguri BSF case is an important scope check. For an all-security-forces outcome it is an earlier matching allegation; for a state-police custodial-reconstruction outcome it is a different category. Central-force incidents must be assigned to their own chain of command rather than attributed automatically to the state government. [18-19]

A comparable measure for the requested question

Build a common event-level dataset across every state and period. Within uniformly retrieved police-shooting reports, record G = immediate gun-taking claims, N = reviewed nonmatches, and U = unresolved mechanisms. With D = G + N + U, report the narrative-share bounds **[G/D, (G+U)/D]**. Report fatal and nonfatal shares separately. This makes missing mechanisms explicit.

Code the state government on the incident date, including coalition status and transition dates. Compare equal observation periods and consistent press coverage. For frequency of genuine attempts, use prisoner transports/reconstructions or armed-custody exposure as the denominator. Population alone is an imperfect substitute. A party-effect analysis needs all states, pretrends, state and time controls, and credible treatment-timing assumptions; a short selected list cannot establish causation.

Do not divide the three 2026 externally verified events by historical headline totals, or compare three article-body matches against zero historical headline matches as an incidence change. The units, time coverage and detection procedures differ.

5. Alternative explanations and research decisions

Explanation/model	How it could generate clustering	Evidence that would help distinguish it
Independent rare events	Unrelated incidents occasionally occur close together	Complete event roster and independently specified baseline/window
Shared operational exposure	More reconstructions or transports on particular dates raise opportunities	Daily reconstruction/transport counts, escort assignments, restraint and firearm-retention records
Common unsafe practice or changed operations	Teams share procedures or face a common operational change	SOPs and dated instructions; consistent before/after records across districts
Shared account or reporting process	Standard police language, wire duplication or attention can repeat narratives	Separate contemporaneous statements, unique article IDs, independent witnesses; entity/event deduplication
Staged or unlawful shootings	A purported seizure could be used to justify a shooting	Independent forensic and inquiry findings, scene video, weapon custody, ballistic and medical evidence

These are competing possibilities, not probabilities assigned to the incidents. The timing data alone cannot rank them. A Bayesian probability for accurate accounts versus staging requires explicit priors and the likelihood of the evidence under each hypothesis, neither supplied by the headline corpus.

Even modest dependence changes the timing benchmark. At a fixed mean of ten events/year, the chance of at least two on a specified day is 0.03685% under Poisson, 0.07111% under an illustrative gamma-Poisson model with shape 1, and 0.29323% with shape 0.1. The latter models allow daily intensity variation. Their parameters are illustrative, not estimated.

What has and has not been established

Established: the local folder and source coverage; a reproducible historical search; an auditable set of candidate records and exclusions; three distinct 2026 reported fatal encounters invoking the mechanism; and independently checked timing calculations. Not established: a complete historical count of the mechanism, its true incidence, an empirical probability that both October accounts are accurate, or a causal party effect.

Extension through the current date

The original scraper itself was rerun on four isolated dates using its original request headers and BeautifulSoup parser. All four produced zero rows, including a known 2015 control; a browser check also showed empty archive lists. A wider computer search recovered the exact January 2, 2003 URL in the first scraper; that unchanged script also returned empty lists. The fallback collected 161 monthly sitemap partitions plus current feeds and their children: 1,424,031 distinct URLs, 2,235 feed-title records and an initial 362 selected article titles/bodies. A symmetric four-state cohort recovered 1,132 article bodies, including 907 not in the initial metadata set.

The updated supplement contains 3,493 distinct content items with actual headlines: 3,322 have article IDs and 171 other news-feed items use URL keys. Of these, 3,108 publication dates are within January 2024 through October 27, 2026 IST; 385 fall on October 28 IST while collection was still October 27 in New York. This is a **partial, selected supplement**. Static sitemap URL slugs and lastmod dates were never substituted for headlines or publication dates. The original-through-2023 tables above remain separate. A separate comparison note reports the exploratory four-state synthetic analysis.

6. Have police parades in underwear happened before?

Yes, including a close precedent with the same stated reconstruction rationale. Clothing, responsible actor and investigative explanation must be coded separately. A naked mob parade is not automatically evidence of a naked police parade.

Place and date	What reporting establishes	Reconstruction stated?
Behror, Rajasthan; 22 September 2019	Police marched 13 handcuffed accused through a market in innerwear, barefoot, for about 2 km. One parade involving 13 people.	Yes. The SP explicitly said officers were recreating the crime scene. [20]
Howrah, West Bengal; May 2026	Three separately accused men were paraded in different neighbourhoods; some wore undershirts and boxer shorts. Reports differ around May 24-25; episode count is unsettled.	Yes, according to officers quoted by Indian Express. This precedes October but follows the May government transition. [21]
Dum Dum jail, West Bengal; 23 August 2010	Nine prisoners allegedly beaten and paraded naked; government inquiry reported. A jail setting, not a public-street episode.	No reconstruction claim established. Broader custodial humiliation precedent only. [22]
Sarsuna/Behala, Kolkata; 27 October 2026	Police brought accused men back shirtless, in shorts/underwear, with ropes. Separate from the original October 25 mob stripping of other victims.	Yes. Do not transfer fully naked descriptions of mob victims to the later police action. [23]

The Rajasthan case directly refutes a claim that underwear parades justified as reconstruction are unprecedented in India. The Howrah examples establish earlier 2026 use in West Bengal. The Dum Dum account establishes an older allegation of a different form of custodial humiliation; it does not establish earlier street reconstruction in underwear.

These are verified examples from a targeted search, not a census of parades. Counting headlines, persons, movements through neighbourhoods and distinct episodes produces different totals. Broad searches for naked/paraded/stripped also retrieve private mob assaults, which must not be included automatically as police conduct. No prevalence estimate or party effect is inferred.

Sources and replication

[1] TOI, initial Baruipur report, 8 July 2026. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[2] TOI, detailed Baruipur report, 9 July 2026. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[3] TOI, Gaighata report, 27 October 2026. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[4] PTI/ThePrint, Murshidabad report, 27 October 2026. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[5] PTI/ThePrint, combined October report. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[6] Grimmer and Stewart (2013), Text as Data, Political Analysis 21(3):267-297. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[7] TOI, Kulti report, 7 February 2002. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[8] TOI, Lucknow report under Kolkata category, 10 August 2005. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[9] TOI, Haridevpur report, 29 June 2014. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[10] TOI, Titagarh follow-up, 18 May 2015. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[11] TOI, Howrah report, 19 October 2015. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[12] TOI, Kankinara report, 13 July 2019. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[12a] TOI, New Town report, 10 June 2021. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[13] NIST/SEMATECH handbook, Poisson distribution. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[14] MHA, Lok Sabha Q292, 15 September 2020, Annexure B. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[15] MHA, Lok Sabha Q1459, 26 July 2022, Annexure II, official alternative domain. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[16] Prime Minister's Office/PIB, West Bengal CM oath, 9 May 2026. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[17] TOI, combined pair report, 28 October IST; retrieved 27 October New York time. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[18] TOI, Jalpaiguri BSF report, 8 March 2025. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[19] MHA annual report 2022-23, section 7.27: central forces including BSF. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[20] TOI, Behror parade, 23 September 2019. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[21] Indian Express, Howrah police parades, 26 May 2026. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[22] TOI, Dum Dum jail allegations, 14 September 2010. Accessed 27 October 2026.

[23] NDTV, Behala police parade, 27 October 2026. Accessed 27 October 2026.

Reproduction and audit files

analyze.py reads the original files without alteration and writes source hashes, annual/daily coverage, complete retrieval patterns and candidate provenance. probability.py reproduces the timing tables; its optional uncertainty illustration uses SciPy. The methods_audit folder contains seeded negative sampling and independent screening labels. events.json records linked 2026 identities, sources and date uncertainty. body_review.json preserves exclusions and unresolved articles. No original millions-row source file is republished in the research package.

This is an exploratory research audit. The dictionary was not preregistered. The independent checks are subagent analytic passes rather than a human gold-standard validation study. A zero retrieved headline count is never interpreted as zero historical events.